showed planned routes to other sugar mills which had been bombed in preceding weeks.[39]

U.S. officials also "categorically and emphatically denied" any connection to a bomb blast which killed between 75 and 100 and injured over 300 in early March 1960. The French ship *La Coubre* had sailed from Antwerp loaded with ammunition and hand grenades purchased by the Cubans. The ship exploded in Havana harbor after being unloaded, and Cuban investigations determined that an explosive device had been planted in the shipment before it left Belgium. U.S. officials did, however, acknowledge that such attempts were consistent with U.S. policy.[40]

The economic side of the conflict escalated when Cuba signed a trade deal with the USSR in February, 1960. In exchange for hundreds of thousands of tons of sugar a year, the Soviets would supply Cuba with oil and manufactured goods. In June, U.S. oil companies on the island refused to process the Soviet petroleum – and the Cuban government promptly expropriated them. In July, Eisenhower drastically cut Cuba's sugar quota. In October, Eisenhower declared an economic embargo of the island, and in January of 1961, severed all diplomatic relations.[41]

Meanwhile, on March 17th, 1960, Eisenhower ordered the creation of a Cuban exile army and began the training and planning that climaxed in the Bay of Pigs invasion of April 1961. The CIA chose its long-time officer E. Howard Hunt to organize Cuban exiles, and escorted hand-picked "opposition leaders" from Havana to serve as the new government. Hunt described his role as to "form and guide the Cuban government-in-exile, accompany its members to a liberated Havana, and stay on as a friendly adviser until after the first post-Castro elections."[42] In return for their loyalty, the CIA funded the new Cuban exile organization liberally: Hunt distributed $115,000 a month for salaries and rentals, and the CIA directly provided "arms, boats and communications equipment for infiltration into Cuba" and other Frente Revolucionario Democrático (FRD) expenses.[43]

Various sources in the U.S. government, including different branches of the CIA which were sometimes unaware of what other branches were